UAE HACKATHON 2026 · CHALLENGE #29 · CYBER RESILIENCE FOR SMEs

Payment Guard

Check it before you pay.

تحقق قبل أن تدفع

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For the UAE Cyber Security Council

THE PROBLEM

The invoice looks right.
The bank account doesn't.

47%

of UAE SMEs surveyed have been hit by a cyberattack

1 in 4

of those hit filed for bankruptcy, and 19% closed

31%

of attacks were phishing, and another 31% ransomware

No security staff, tight budgets, and an owner who has to decide alone whether to pay.

Source: Mastercard SME cybersecurity research, 23 April 2025. Over 1,000 UAE SME owners surveyed.

LIVE DEMO

A scam lands in a real Gmail inbox.

1

Labelled

"do not pay" in the shop's own Gmail

2

Phone buzzes

a WhatsApp alert before anyone pays

3

Forwarded

any message or screenshot on WhatsApp

4

Others warned

shared with businesses in the sector

Two minutes, live. If Gmail or WhatsApp fails, the backup video plays.

WHAT WE BUILT

A working slice of the SME Cyber Care Pathway

R2 Verify

Scam emails labelled "do not pay" in the shop's own Gmail. Anything forwarded on WhatsApp, checked in seconds.

R3 Know who to call

Every warning names the first call: the supplier on the number on file, the bank, or the Cyber Security Council.

R5 Shared warnings

One business's report warns others in its sector, without names. Independent reports confirm it.

+ Understand risks

A 10-question ransomware readiness check, and a response card to print and keep by the till.

NEXT, AND OUR ASK

Put it in front of 20 real shops

We're asking for

1. A 3-month pilot with 20 small businesses, through a free zone or a chamber of commerce.

2. An introduction to the right team at the UAE Cyber Security Council, so owners' reports reach the national channel.

What comes next

Before anyone hosts it: login, encrypted mailbox access, and a security review.

Product: setup on the web page, Outlook tested on real mailboxes, and real threat feeds.

Price: free during the pilot. We'll set the price from what the pilot actually costs to run.

THE CHALLENGE ASKS

BACKUP

“How might we enable SMEs across the UAE to protect themselves from everyday threats like phishing, invoice fraud, and ransomware…”

Cause	The gap	What Payment Guard does
R2	Advice isn't turned into decisions	A plain verdict: Stop, Needs a look, Safe
R3	Owners don't know who to contact	Every warning names the first call
R5	Shared learning is hard	One report warns others in its sector

Out of scope, and we say so: R1 and R4 (business-continuity governance, supplier contracts).

NO WEBSITE TO REMEMBER

BACKUP

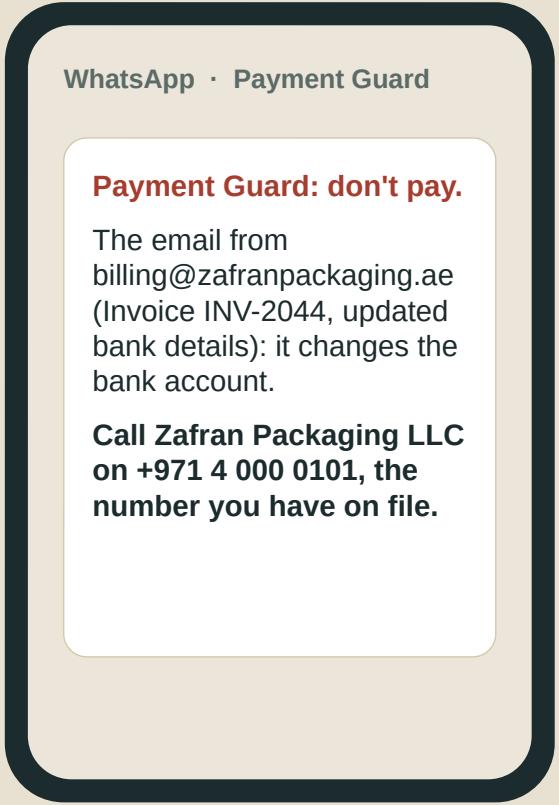
It works where scams arrive

1. **Email**
   scams labelled in the shop's own inbox, with a note saying who to call

2. **Phone**
   a WhatsApp alert the moment a scam is stopped

3. **WhatsApp**
   forward any message, PDF or screenshot to one number

4. **Web page**
   the full evidence, side by side



The real alert for our demo invoice email

WHY IT CAN BE TRUSTED

BACKUP

Built so owners and the Council can rely on it

Explainable rules

Every warning says why, in plain Arabic or English. Fixed rules, no AI guessing.

Hard to abuse

One report is a warning. It takes independent reports to confirm, so a competitor can't get a supplier blocked.

Private by design

It never stores email or message content. Logs keep only the verdict and the reasons.

Fits the national strategy

Governance, protection, innovation, establishing and building, and partnership: one line each in our strategy mapping.